Genesis to Revelation

By Donald Excell

In eighteen thirty-eight, on the abolition of slavery, Edward Samuels walked away from the plantation in Westmoreland where he was born and raised for the past fourteen years as property. He walked behind his father's horse to the hills of Donalva District in Hanover where his father, a slave driver, bought and settled him on forty acres of land.

Edward later married Julia Brown was blessed with nine sons and became a prosperous yam farmer. His sons, particularly John and Josh, continued the farming and contributed to the fame and the name of the so-called Lucea yam. The property expanded to two hundred and fifty acres and after gifting a hundred acres had settled at a hundred and twenty-five acres.

The family continued mainly yam farming until the retirement of Edward's granddaughter Agnes Samuels, age of ninety-two, in nineteen ninety-one. The yam vines would grow on bamboo sticks which, despite the cessation of yam farming, continued to grow covering the entire property with a species of bamboo named ***Bambusa vulgaris*** and its mutant ***Bambusa vittata***.

In the year two thousand and nineteen (2019), Edward's great granddaughter Phyllis Cutie Samuels Excell determined that she wanted to return to Jamaica specifically to Barrel to live after living abroad for many years and I decided to return with her as we both had spent our earliest years in Barrel.

In two thousand and nineteen we were faced with a property wide proliferation of bamboo. Donald Excell approached Mr. Gladstone Rose at the Bureau of Standards Jamaica (BSJ) for advice on what to do with the bamboo. Mr. Rose suggested making bamboo charcoal and activated charcoal which is used to purify gold, make granulated sugar (white sugar), and is used as a medicine for the removal of poison from the stomach.

This seemed like a good idea because bamboo is the only charcoal which is naturally activated on being carbonized. With Mr. Rose's continued advice and guidance, by two thousand and twenty-three December (2023), we were able to produce activated bamboo charcoal.

However because of the need to test for activation and the time of seven weeks to get results from the laboratory, we decided to make bamboo barbecue charcoal instead which we had mastered years before. However the culms of Bambusa vulgaris were very thin so we decided to convert bamboo charcoal to bamboo charcoal briquettes.

We have since developed a product in collaboration with Mr. Rose that, to quote Mr. Rose, "my research tells me that your present formulation can do the following: A practical estimate is that twenty pounds of your briquette can be used to cook roughly eighty to a hundred pounds of chicken depending on the grill size and cooking method and heat control."

The prototype was tested by a barbecue chef who has previously cooked for three Jamaican Prime Ministers and we have video recording of the same.

The products we are now manufacturing are a cinnamon-flavored bamboo charcoal briquette and a pimento flavored bamboo charcoal briquette. We also offer a fire starter made from honeycomb and bamboo shavings.

Our products are what I would call "Ital".

Last revised on 07 May 2026